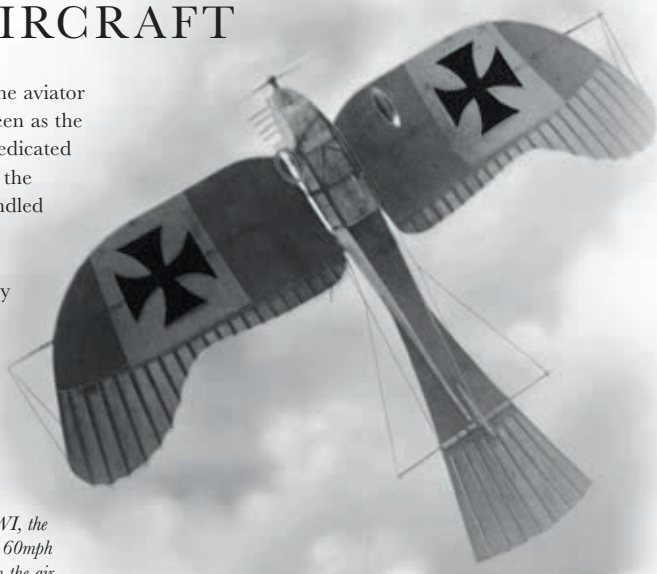


WWI RECONNAISSANCE AIRCRAFT

AT THE START OF WWI, the German General Staff stated that “the duty of the aviator is to see, not to fight.” Given that reconnaissance and artillery spotting were seen as the central purpose of military aviation, it is perhaps surprising that the aircraft dedicated to this role often had such poor performance – from frail monoplanes, such as the Taube, used at the outset of the war, to the many unexciting biplanes that trundled over the trenches. Stability was regarded as the chief virtue of reconnaissance machines, in order to provide a platform for observation and photography. But this meant they were slow and clumsy to maneuver, making them easy prey for enemy fighters and vulnerable to ground fire. Some, such as the Renault A.R. and the RAF R.E.8, had a particularly poor reputation. After a spate of accidents, the R.E.8 was temporarily withdrawn from service, but investigations revealed inadequate training rather than poor design to be the culprit. Late in WWI, progress came on the Allied side with the introduction of the Bristol F.2B fighter for reconnaissance. Improved cameras allowed the Germans to initiate high-altitude photo-reconnaissance outside the range of most fighter aircraft.

VULNERABLE DOVE

Already outdated by the outbreak of WWI, the Rumpler Taube only had a top speed of 60mph (97kph) and was extremely vulnerable in the air.



Caudron Type G.IV

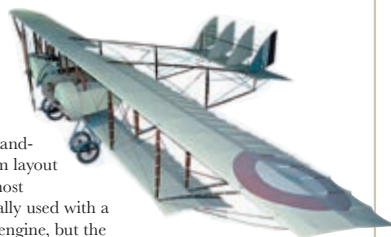
The nacelle-and-tailboom layout was almost universally used with a pusher engine, but the series of Caudron airplanes differed in using tractor engines. The G.IV performed a variety of roles in addition to that of reconnaissance, including bomber and trainer.

ENGINE 2 x 80hp Le Rhone 9-cylinder rotary

WINGSPAN 56ft 5in (17.2m) **LENGTH** 23ft 8in (7.2m)

TOP SPEED 82mph (132kph) **CREW** 2

ARMAMENT 2 x 7mm machine gun



Farman H.F.20

With the outbreak of war, the Farman brothers' factory received large orders for the Maurice-designed M.F.7 and 11 and for Henri's H.F.20. Its primary duty in France was in an observation role until mid-1915, when it became a trainer.

ENGINE Gnome 7A 7-cylinder rotary

WINGSPAN 44ft 10in (15.5m) **LENGTH** 27ft 9in (8.8m)

TOP SPEED 62mph (100kph) **CREW** 2

ARMAMENT None



RAF B.E.2c

The B.E.2 was an observation machine – slow, stable, and unarmed. It was immediately obvious that some form of defense was needed, so the B.E.2c, introduced in October 1914, was equipped with a machine gun in the observer's cockpit.

ENGINE 90hp Royal Aircraft Factory 1a V-8 air-cooled

WINGSPAN 37ft (11.29m) **LENGTH** 27ft 3in (8.3m)

TOP SPEED 75mph (120kph) **CREW** 2

ARMAMENT 1 x .303in Lewis machine gun in observer's cockpit (can carry up to four); 230lb (104kg) bombload (when flown solo)



RAF R.E.8

The R.E.8, known to its crews as the “Harry Tate” after a musical-hall comedian of the day, replaced the outmoded B.E.2c. Entering service in 1916, it became the most widely used reconnaissance and artillery spotting aircraft operated by the R.E.C. during WWI.

ENGINE 140hp Royal Aircraft Factory 4a air-cooled V-12

WINGSPAN 42ft 7in (13m) **LENGTH** 27ft 10in (8.5m)

TOP SPEED 102mph (164kph) **CREW** 2

ARMAMENT 1 x .303in Vickers machine gun; 1 x .303in Lewis machine gun in observer's cockpit; 224lb (101kg) bombload



Rumpler Taube

Instantly recognizable by its sweptback, birdlike wing tips, which warped for flight control, the Austrian Taube (“Dove”) had its origins in the Etrich-Wels glider of 1907. Manufacture was initially licensed to Rumpler, and the design is now generally associated with that company. Although a prewar design, its initial success as a reconnaissance machine on the Western Front led to it being built by Albatross, Gotha, and D.F.W.

ENGINE 100hp Mercedes D1, 6-cylinder liquid-cooled inline

WINGSPAN 47ft 7in (14.5m) **LENGTH** 32ft 10in (10m)

TOP SPEED 60mph (97kph) **CREW** 2

ARMAMENT None

